

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Shah Jahan & the Evolution of the Mughal Ruling Class - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

MEDIEVAL HISTORY 21 | VISUAL 01

Shah Jahan: visible magnificence, managed strain

1

1628-1658: succession, expansion and courtly sovereignty

Use as an answer-writing evidence cue.

2

Read two axes together: visible capacity and hidden mismatch

Use as an answer-writing evidence cue.

3

Core lens: ruling class, mansab, jagir, jama and succession

Use as an answer-writing evidence cue.

4

FACT / ANALYSIS discipline; no automatic decline story

Use as an answer-writing evidence cue.

Original deterministic study visual | Dates and quantities follow the source-risk notes in this package.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ loop - original (correct options A-B-C-D x5)

Q1. Which statement best defines a Mughal jagir in this topic?

- A. A transferable assignment of a state revenue claim linked to service
- B. Unrestricted private ownership of a province
- C. A cash pension unrelated to military obligations
- D. A hereditary village office held by every zamindar

Answer: A. Explanation: The key discriminator is assignment of revenue claim rather than proprietary title; the land-ownership option is the classic translation error.

Q2. In the mature Akbari dual-rank framework, zat primarily expressed:

- A. the number of months for which a jagir yielded revenue
- B. personal status and the related pay grade
- C. a prince's territorial base
- D. the actual annual hasil of a jagir

Answer: B. Explanation: Zat is a hierarchy-and-pay field. Sawar, not zat, is the field that connects a mansab to cavalry obligation.

Q3. What did the sawar component of a mansab specify?

- A. the crown's reserved revenue
- B. the noble's legal title to land
- C. the stipulated cavalry obligation
- D. the amount of jama retained as khalisa

Answer: C. Explanation: Sawar concerns cavalry service. The khalisa option confuses crown revenue with a personal rank field.

Q4. Du-aspa sih-aspa, as placed in the assigned source tradition, is associated first with:

- A. Shah Jahan
- B. Alauddin Khalji
- C. Aurangzeb
- D. Jahangir

Answer: D. Explanation: The placement under Jahangir is the chronology test; Shah Jahan inherited and managed later adjustments rather than inventing this device.

Q5. The most careful reading of du-aspa sih-aspa is that it:

- A. increased specified cavalry obligation without necessarily raising zat
- B. doubled every component of a noble's mansab
- C. abolished branding of horses
- D. converted jagir into hereditary property

Answer: A. Explanation: It modifies specified military duty. The 'whole mansab doubled' lure ignores the separate zat and sawar fields.

Q6. Dag and chehra are best understood as:

- A. titles for Rajput contingents
- B. branding and descriptive-muster controls intended to check fraud

- C. two categories of khalisa land
- D. a pair of Shah Jahan's architectural offices

Answer: B. Explanation: Branding and descriptive rolls are verification devices. They did not guarantee that borrowed men or horses could never be presented.

Q7. Which provenance sequence is correct for dagh/chehra controls?

- A. Sher Shah invented them; Alauddin copied him; Akbar ended them
- B. Akbar invented them; Jahangir abandoned them; Shah Jahan restored them
- C. Alauddin Khalji used them; Sher Shah revived/adapted them; Akbar systematised them
- D. Shah Jahan created them solely for Deccan warfare

Answer: C. Explanation: The sequence guards against an Akbar-first or Shah Jahan-invented claim while preserving the difference between use and systematisation.

Q8. Jama is most accurately described as:

- A. a mansabdar's personal status rank
- B. a fortification assessment
- C. actual realised collection in every year
- D. assessed or estimated revenue

Answer: D. Explanation: Jama is an assessment claim; hasil is realised collection. Treating jama as cash in hand erases the fiscal problem the month-scale addresses.

Q9. Hasil refers to:

- A. actual realised collection
- B. the crown's reserved revenue
- C. a city foundation process
- D. a nominal rank increase under du-aspa

Answer: A. Explanation: Hasil is the realised side of the revenue vocabulary. Khalisa is crown-reserved revenue, not a synonym for collection.

Q10. The month-scale was designed principally to:

- A. grant a bonus to officers sent to difficult districts
- B. scale pay and service claims to a jagir's effective month rating
- C. end all transfer of jagirdars
- D. make every jagir a full twelve-month yield

Answer: B. Explanation: It records and adjusts for a shortfall; it does not transform a weak yield into a reward or abolish imperial rotation.

Q11. The repository's cited Deccan three-to-four-month cases illustrate:

- A. that Qandahar was a Deccan province
- B. that jagirs became freehold estates
- C. a high assessed jama could coexist with a low effective return
- D. that Deccan posts were uniformly the richest

Answer: C. Explanation: The point is the jama-hasil mismatch under difficult conditions; 'richest posts' reverses the source-bound implication.

Q12. The source-bound jama series 100, about 122, about 176 should be used as:

- A. a count of mansabdars by reign
- B. a price series for marble
- C. a measurement of uniform peasant prosperity
- D. an index of assessed revenue claims, not GDP or actual cash

Answer: D. Explanation: It is an assessed-revenue index. The other readings add a denominator and meaning the source does not provide.

Q13. Which statement best captures Shah Jahan's fiscal condition?

- A. managed strain in a functioning system, not a completed later crisis
- B. a fiscally effortless golden age
- C. an empire already administratively collapsed in 1628
- D. a system without any jagir mismatch before Aurangzeb

Answer: A. Explanation: The calibrated verdict holds resource pressure and functioning administration together; both extreme alternatives flatten chronology.

Q14. The standard chronology for Mumtaz Mahal's death is:

- A. 1630
- B. 1631
- C. 1658
- D. 1638

Answer: B. Explanation: Use 1631. The assigned Part II note's 1630 printing is a documented source discrepancy/typo, not the standard fact.

Q15. Shahjahanabad's relevant date and caution are:

- A. 1658 foundation by Aurangzeb as a successor city
- B. 1628 foundation before accession; it had no market life
- C. 1638 foundation/transfer process; it was not built in a single year
- D. 1649 foundation after Qandahar's loss; it was completed at once

Answer: C. Explanation: 1638 anchors the project, while a process framing prevents the false image of an instantly completed city.

Q16. The 1646-47 Balkh venture is best summarised as:

- A. a Deccan revenue settlement
- B. a campaign led after Shah Jahan's deposition
- C. permanent annexation that solved the northwest frontier
- D. temporary military success that proved strategically and logistically unsustainable

Answer: D. Explanation: Balkh demonstrates that battlefield performance and sustainable possession differ; permanent annexation overstates the result.

Q17. Qandahar was lost to Safavid Persia in:

- A. 1649
- B. 1628
- C. 1657
- D. 1633

Answer: A. Explanation: 1649 is the required frontier date. 1633 belongs to Ahmadnagar's end, while 1657 is the illness trigger.

Q18. The 1657 illness matters because it:

- A. created a fixed Turani-Irani war
- B. activated a contest in a polity without a fixed primogeniture rule
- C. ended all provincial commands
- D. automatically installed Dara Shukoh as constitutional heir

Answer: B. Explanation: The illness made access and reward uncertain; it did not supply an automatic legal succession or ethnic alignment formula.

Q19. A sound statement about Mughal noble composition is that:

- A. foreign-born elites disappeared under Shah Jahan
- B. all Rajputs held identical rank and loyalty
- C. the Indian element broadened while immigrant groups remained important
- D. one exact percentage applies without date or denominator

Answer: C. Explanation: The direction of change is supportable in the assigned notes; an unqualified percentage would pretend to data the package does not establish.

Q20. Shahji Bhonsale is used in this topic as:

- A. the founder of Shahjahanabad
- B. a Safavid governor of Qandahar
- C. proof of mass, stable Maratha incorporation
- D. a bounded example of elite movement and service in the Deccan field

Answer: D. Explanation: His case shows selective elite incorporation; it cannot bear a claim about all Marathas or later Shivaji's full career.

Broad technical MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x11)

Q21. Why can monuments be used as evidence for state capacity?

- A. They show coordination of labour, materials, workshops and court demand
- B. They make administrative records unnecessary
- C. They directly reveal the empire's annual cash balance
- D. They prove uniform rural prosperity

Answer: A. Explanation: Monuments demonstrate mobilisation and ideology, not a complete fiscal ledger or social survey.

Q22. Which is the best distinction between jagirdar and zamindar?

- A. A jagirdar is the same as khalisa
- B. An imperial assignee differs from a locally rooted intermediary category
- C. A zamindar is always a transferable mansabdar
- D. Both are identical legal owners of all village land

Answer: B. Explanation: Transferable imperial assignment versus rooted local claims is the core distinction; the other options collapse categories.

Q23. A short-rated jagir could encourage which response?

- A. end of all imperial dependence
- B. conversion of jama into hasil by definition
- C. competition for a better posting and pressure on local revenue channels
- D. automatic abolition of cavalry obligations

Answer: C. Explanation: Shortfall creates incentives around postings and collection; it does not magically convert assessment into cash.

Q24. Which factor is NOT sufficient by itself to explain inflated jama?

- A. distance and collection difficulty
- B. war and interrupted cultivation
- C. survey or assessment error
- D. a universal assumption that every officer committed fraud

Answer: D. Explanation: Fraud may occur, but the package requires a multi-causal explanation including war, survey and control.

Q25. The 1636 Deccan settlement should be described as:

- A. a temporary political framework, not total annexation of all Deccan states
- B. permanent incorporation of every Deccan polity
- C. a post-1658 arrangement
- D. a Safavid-Mughal treaty over Qandahar

Answer: A. Explanation: It involved a bounded settlement with Bijapur and Golconda; total annexation is inaccurate.

Q26. Why do rank awards create fiscal pressure?

- A. They eliminate the need for jagirs
- B. They generate salary and service claims that need support
- C. They automatically raise realised hasil
- D. They reduce the number of court households

Answer: B. Explanation: A rank is a claim on remuneration and service support; it cannot itself increase collection.

Q27. A high sawar number should NOT be assumed to prove:

- A. that a cavalry obligation existed
- B. that verification mattered
- C. that the stated number of troops was always campaign-effective
- D. that remount resources were relevant

Answer: C. Explanation: Nominal obligation and actual force are distinct, which is why muster controls and evasion matter.

Q28. What does transfer of jagirdars seek to preserve?

- A. the abolition of central appointment
- B. permanent village ownership by assignees
- C. hereditary provincial sovereignty
- D. imperial dependence and limits on local entrenchment

Answer: D. Explanation: Rotation is a central lever, although it can also create short-term extraction incentives.

Q29. Court ceremony is relevant to political analysis because it:

- A. orders access, precedence and the public image of sovereignty
- B. establishes modern equality before law
- C. proves no noble bargaining occurred
- D. replaces military command and revenue

Answer: A. Explanation: Ritual is political representation, not a substitute for all coercive and fiscal institutions.

Q30. The term 'composite elite' is strongest when it means:

- A. a permanent ethnic federation with fixed voting blocs
- B. a coalition incorporating varied service networks under imperial appointment
- C. a modern representative legislature
- D. an elite without factional rivalry

Answer: B. Explanation: Composite describes varied incorporation, not modern representation or an absence of competition.

Q31. The best reason to avoid an exact noble-composition percentage here is:

- A. Mansabs had no numerical rank

- B. all chronicles prohibit counting
- C. the package lacks a stated dataset, date, rank threshold and denominator
- D. percentages are never useful in history

Answer: C. Explanation: Quantification is valid only when its population and method travel with it; the absolute ban and factual claims are wrong.

Q32. Khalisa revenue is:

- A. a cavalry allowance within sawar
- B. a Rajput kinship tie
- C. a synonym for hasil
- D. revenue retained for the crown rather than assigned as jagir

Answer: D. Explanation: Khalisa concerns crown-reserved revenue. It is neither realised collection nor a personal rank.

Q33. A watan jagir should be handled as:

- A. a context-specific locally/hereditarily associated grant category
- B. another name for du-aspa sih-aspa
- C. proof that every jagir was freely inheritable
- D. a universal cash salary

Answer: A. Explanation: The term signals a different relationship but cannot erase the broader distinction between legal rule and local association.

Q34. Which is the safest inference from the 1657-58 war?

- A. primogeniture was violated
- B. succession uncertainty made noble patronage calculations high stakes
- C. each origin group chose one prince permanently
- D. all state institutions ceased at illness

Answer: B. Explanation: There was no fixed primogeniture rule to violate; the war reveals a vulnerable transfer mechanism, not ethnic determinism.

Q35. Dharmat and Samugarh belong to:

- A. the 1649 Qandahar recovery
- B. the 1636 Deccan settlement
- C. the 1658 phase of the succession struggle
- D. the 1646 Balkh expedition

Answer: C. Explanation: These battles are part of the 1658 contest, while the distractors shift them to unrelated campaign dates.

Q36. Khajwa and Deorai are useful here because they:

- A. are sites of the Taj Mahal
- B. ended Ahmadnagar in 1633
- C. mark Shah Jahan's accession in 1628
- D. show that succession consolidation extended beyond the first 1658 battles

Answer: D. Explanation: They belong to the extended 1659 consolidation, avoiding the false impression that Samugarh alone ended every contest.

Q37. Which claim about architecture is methodologically weakest?

- A. The Taj Mahal alone caused the later Mughal decline
- B. Architecture expressed sovereignty
- C. Court demand could support craft markets

- D. Monuments required coordinated resources

Answer: A. Explanation: Single-cause decline claims cannot be inferred from a monument; the other statements make bounded evidence claims.

Q38. The Taj Mahal link to the reign should be dated with the correction that:

- A. the tomb proves a 1658 accession
- B. Mumtaz Mahal died in 1631 despite a 1630 typo in the assigned note
- C. Mumtaz died in 1638 when Shahjahanabad was founded
- D. the Taj is a Qandahar monument

Answer: B. Explanation: 1631 is the standard date; the other answers attach the monument to unrelated dates or events.

Q39. What does the accessible SRDC Jama Masjid page safely provide for this export?

- A. a direct record of Shah Jahan's construction accounts
- B. a current event that may be dated without checking
- C. a static urban-conservation comparison with no verified six-month dated CA anchor
- D. proof of a 2026 Mughal revenue policy

Answer: C. Explanation: The page describes precinct planning but lacks the qualifying date required for a fresh CA claim; it is retained only as a bounded static link.

Q40. Why are Padshahnama-style chronicles insufficient by themselves?

- A. They contain no dates or appointments
- B. they are architectural plans
- C. they are modern statistical surveys
- D. They foreground courtly order and may be selective about suffering or failure

Answer: D. Explanation: Court chronicles are valuable for ceremony and appointments, but genre and purpose limit their social reach.

Q41. Administrative tables require caution because:

- A. nominal categories may not equal actual cash, troops or complete populations
- B. they are always traveller accounts
- C. numbers can never be compared
- D. they eliminate all need for source criticism

Answer: A. Explanation: Tables can reveal patterns, but category and survival limitations prevent a direct leap to actual force or income.

Q42. European traveller evidence should be used as:

- A. a replacement for Persian chronicles
- B. a situated observation to be triangulated with other evidence
- C. a source that applies only before Akbar
- D. a universal census of rural society

Answer: B. Explanation: Travellers offer observations filtered by position and comparison; they neither replace nor universally invalidate court sources.

Q43. What is the most accurate claim about Bernier in this topic?

- A. his prose is an official revenue table
- B. he proves every jagir failed
- C. His later observations cannot be transparently projected onto all of Shah Jahan's reign
- D. He was a Padshahnama author

Answer: C. Explanation: Chronology and viewpoint limit Bernier's reach; he remains useful with explicit qualification.

Q44. Why does a Deccan posting require a multi-factor analysis?

- A. all Deccan offices were identical
- B. Deccan geography automatically prevents any revenue
- C. only ethnicity determines a posting's value
- D. terrain, war, control, survey and collection affect effective yield

Answer: D. Explanation: The package rejects geographical determinism and ethnic reduction while recognising material constraints.

Q45. What did Shah Jahan inherit rather than invent?

- A. the mansab-jagir framework with its Akbari foundations
- B. the standard date 1631 for Mumtaz's death
- C. the Safavid capture of Qandahar
- D. the 1657 illness

Answer: A. Explanation: Institutional inheritance is the point; the other choices are events or dates, not an administrative framework.

Q46. An imperial favour could advance a noble because:

- A. the system was an anonymous modern civil service
- B. appointment and patronage were central to rank and access
- C. jagirs were legally automatic inheritances
- D. all ranks were elected by zamindars

Answer: B. Explanation: Imperial appointment sat at the system's centre, alongside household and kin networks; election and automatic inheritance are anachronisms.

Q47. Why is legal non-heredity compatible with elite family continuity?

- A. no family could have court contact twice
- B. rank depended only on land ownership
- C. social capital, clients, training and reputation can transmit advantages
- D. mansabs automatically passed to eldest sons

Answer: C. Explanation: The distinction between legal rule and social reproduction is exactly what the question tests.

Q48. Which is the best interpretation of a faction in 1657-58?

- A. a biologically fixed ethnic camp
- B. a modern political party with a manifesto
- C. a village revenue unit
- D. a shifting patronage alignment around princes, rewards and survival

Answer: D. Explanation: Faction is relational and temporal; fixed ethnicity and modern-party language distort the court setting.

Q49. Why did princely households matter to fiscal politics?

- A. they could generate commands, rewards and competing claims on resources
- B. they converted all jagirs to khalisa
- C. they made succession automatic
- D. they removed princes from military affairs

Answer: A. Explanation: Households are nodes of patronage and command, intensifying competition when the emperor is incapacitated.

Q50. The word 'suzerainty' is useful for the 1636 settlement only when it:

- A. means equal modern state sovereignty
- B. distinguishes a hierarchical relation from complete annexation
- C. means no military pressure existed
- D. proves Bijapur and Golconda vanished

Answer: B. Explanation: A hierarchy may preserve internal courts; equating it with equality or disappearance loses the political form.

Q51. Why are campaign expenditure figures omitted here?

- A. cost has no analytical relevance
- B. all Mughal campaigns were costless
- C. the assigned sources do not securely establish a figure for this use
- D. money did not exist in imperial administration

Answer: C. Explanation: Cost is analytically relevant but must not be fabricated; named logistics and claims provide safer evidence.

Q52. A high jama in a newly acquired tract may still fail to support a mansabdar because:

- A. transfer guarantees a full yield
- B. sawar removes all collection risk
- C. jama is another word for realised cash
- D. assessment and actual collection can diverge

Answer: D. Explanation: The jama-hasil distinction drives the answer; neither transfer nor rank removes collection problems.

Q53. Which claim properly links month-scale and peasant pressure?

- A. short-rated assignments could create extraction incentives but do not prove uniform oppression
- B. no local intermediary mattered
- C. every month-rated jagir automatically caused famine
- D. the month-scale benefited cultivators by definition

Answer: A. Explanation: The language must be conditional and multi-actor; automatic famine and benefit claims exceed the evidence.

Q54. A careful Mains conclusion on 'golden age' should:

- A. treat revenue assessment as a welfare survey
- B. separate courtly magnificence from distributional and fiscal conditions
- C. declare all subjects prosperous from monument size
- D. deny any imperial capacity because Qandahar was lost

Answer: B. Explanation: A graded conclusion preserves both evidence of capacity and limits of its social reach.

Q55. What does the 1638 capital project show most directly?

- A. the start of Aurangzeb's reign
- B. a proof that every province paid full jama
- C. urban sovereignty and the court's capacity to organise a capital process
- D. a city completed in twelve months

Answer: C. Explanation: The project demonstrates coordination, but its timing and scale cannot be converted into unrelated fiscal or reign claims.

Q56. The best use of a schematic map in this topic is to:

- A. supply precise survey measurements

- B. prove modern national borders
- C. replace chronology
- D. show strategic relationships while marking that it is not to scale

Answer: D. Explanation: Schematic maps aid spatial reasoning but cannot offer survey precision or erase temporal evidence.

Q57. Which formulation of the Deccan fiscal issue is strongest?

- A. nominal resources and realisable revenue were separated by war, control and collection
- B. Deccan was simply poor on every measure
- C. the issue was irrelevant to mansabdari
- D. Deccan was simply rich on every measure

Answer: A. Explanation: The source says inflated jama and low ratings can coexist; simple rich/poor labels miss the mechanism.

Q58. What does 'mansab inflation' most safely mean?

- A. the end of the mansab system
- B. growth in nominal rank and military-salary claims
- C. a rise in food prices only
- D. proof that every listed troop existed

Answer: B. Explanation: Inflation is about paper claims and rank burden, not a direct census of soldiers or price movement.

Q59. Why could dagh/chehra not eliminate fraud entirely?

- A. chehra was a monument
- B. all officers refused inspection
- C. a snapshot muster could be evaded by borrowed horses or temporary men
- D. branding had no verification purpose

Answer: C. Explanation: The devices were meaningful checks, but the source's borrowed-contingent problem demonstrates their limits.

Q60. Which contrast is sound?

- A. Aurangzeb preceded Shah Jahan
- B. Akbar had no mansabdari and Shah Jahan invented it
- C. Jahangir created every jagir in 1657
- D. Akbar's foundation/systematisation versus Shah Jahan's mature adjustment under strain

Answer: D. Explanation: The contrast preserves institutional continuity and changing pressure rather than inventing a Shah Jahan origin.

Q61. Which statement avoids a premature-decline narrative?

- A. later jagirdari crisis matured under Aurangzeb and after, though roots were visible earlier
- B. month-scale means collapse occurred in 1628
- C. architecture alone explains all later events
- D. no fiscal pressure existed before 1707

Answer: A. Explanation: The right answer is chronological: roots and later maturation differ; both absolute alternatives are false.

Q62. Why is Qandahar relevant to this topic?

- A. it eliminates the need to study Balkh
- B. it tests logistics, princely command and the limits of frontier projection
- C. it proves all Safavid policy was domestic

- D. it was a Deccan month-rated jagir

Answer: B. Explanation: Qandahar is a bounded state-capacity case; it is neither a Deccan assignment nor a substitute for all frontier analysis.

Q63. Why does Balkh not equal permanent expansion?

- A. Balkh was never entered by a Mughal force
- B. it was founded by Shah Jahan as a capital
- C. retention and supply are separate from temporary battlefield success
- D. all expeditions yield permanent provinces

Answer: C. Explanation: The distinction between tactical success and durable sustainability is the required reasoning.

Q64. Which source would most directly record a courtly appointment?

- A. a later traveller's general comparison
- B. a modern satellite map
- C. a schematic revision diagram
- D. a Padshahnama-type court chronicle

Answer: D. Explanation: Chronicles are highly useful for appointment and ceremonial claims, although they require genre criticism for broader social conclusions.

Remedial MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x4)

Q65. A student calls Shah Jahan's reign a 'golden age' and concludes every subject prospered. What is the correction?

- A. Courtly splendour does not establish universal prosperity
- B. No courtly wealth existed at all
- C. Jama is a direct welfare index
- D. Monuments prove every cultivator received equal income

Answer: A. Explanation: The error is a perspective jump from court evidence to every subject; the correction retains splendour while demanding social evidence.

Q66. A student says the Taj Mahal caused Mughal decline. What is the best response?

- A. Architecture has no political-economic meaning
- B. A single monument cannot establish causation without wider fiscal comparison
- C. The Taj was built after 1707
- D. All military costs were irrelevant

Answer: B. Explanation: The claim needs evidence of scale and competing demands; denying architecture's meaning or shifting dates does not repair causation.

Q67. Which date should replace the repository Part II's printed 1630 for Mumtaz Mahal's death?

- A. 1638
- B. 1657
- C. 1631
- D. 1628

Answer: C. Explanation: The remedy is precise: 1631 is standard; 1630 is retained only in the fact-risk note as a typo.

Q68. A student says sawar equals personal status. What is the correction?

- A. Zat is a Deccan treaty
- B. Sawar denotes crown revenue; zat denotes actual hasil
- C. Both denote only city planning

- D. Sawar denotes cavalry obligation; zat denotes personal status/pay grade

Answer: D. Explanation: The two fields perform different work. The first option is the required pairwise correction.

Q69. A student says du-aspa sih-aspa automatically raises zat. What is the correction?

- A. It increases specified cavalry obligation without itself raising zat
- B. It changes jama into hasil
- C. It is a Shahjahanabad market tax
- D. It makes jagirs hereditary

Answer: A. Explanation: The trap is to collapse military enhancement into personal rank; the other choices are unrelated vocabulary errors.

Q70. A student says Shah Jahan invented mansabdari and dagh. What is the correction?

- A. Jahangir abolished all verification
- B. He inherited an Akbari system; dagh/chehra have earlier Alauddin-Sher Shah-Akbar provenance
- C. dagh is a type of mausoleum
- D. mansab began only after 1658

Answer: B. Explanation: The remedy combines institutional continuity with the correct control provenance; it rejects a Shah Jahan origin myth.

Q71. A student calls a jagir the noble's owned land. What is the correction?

- A. It was a uniform village caste title
- B. It had no link to service
- C. It was a transferable assignment of state revenue claim
- D. It was always khalisa

Answer: C. Explanation: This distinction prevents a freehold translation; service-linked assignment is the operative institutional idea.

Q72. A student equates jama with money actually collected. What is the correction?

- A. hasil is a type of monument
- B. Jama is cavalry, while hasil is rank
- C. both mean permanent property
- D. Jama is assessed revenue, while hasil is realised collection

Answer: D. Explanation: The answer restores the assessment-realisation gap that makes month ratings intelligible.

Q73. A student calls the month-scale a bonus for officers. What is the correction?

- A. It reduced/scaled entitlement to an effective month rating
- B. It guaranteed twelve months' full yield
- C. It created primogeniture
- D. It abolished cavalry service

Answer: A. Explanation: It is an accounting adjustment for shortfall, not a premium allowance or constitutional rule.

Q74. A student says any month-rating proves the full later jagirdari crisis had already occurred. What is the correction?

- A. It proves no strain existed
- B. It signals managed strain and roots, not the completed later crisis
- C. it ends all transfers
- D. it refers only to art history

Answer: B. Explanation: The temporal qualifier matters: a pressure-management device cannot be collapsed into the whole later crisis.

Q75. A student calls every Deccan jagir a rich reward. What is the correction?

- A. Qandahar lay in the Deccan
- B. all Deccan revenue was khalisa
- C. Source-bound cases show inflated jama and low effective ratings could make postings unattractive
- D. Deccan had no administrative relevance

Answer: C. Explanation: The remedy keeps the mismatch between assessed and usable return, rather than treating an expansive region as uniformly rich.

Q76. A student inserts an exact composition percentage without citation. What is the correction?

- A. Percentages become valid if written in bold
- B. all categories were legally identical
- C. no historian may discuss composition
- D. State the trend or supply a dataset, date, denominator and method

Answer: D. Explanation: Precision requires a defined population and method; typography cannot convert an unsupported figure into evidence.

Q77. A student says Mughal nobility was legally hereditary. What is the correction?

- A. Mansabs were imperial grants, though family networks reproduced advantage socially
- B. Every son automatically inherited zat
- C. jagirdars elected successors
- D. families were absent from court

Answer: A. Explanation: Legal non-heredity and social reproduction must be held together; either extreme loses the institutional nuance.

Q78. A student says succession factions were fixed ethnic camps. What is the correction?

- A. only zamindars chose emperors
- B. Alignments shifted with patrons, princes, rewards and military circumstances
- C. Origin labels never existed
- D. all nobles avoided the war

Answer: B. Explanation: Origin categories existed but did not mechanically determine allegiance; patronage logic is the closer explanation.

Q79. A student says the 1657-58 war instantly destroyed the empire. What is the correction?

- A. It was a peaceful primogeniture transfer
- B. it was only a monument dispute
- C. It violently reconfigured the command centre without instant institutional collapse
- D. it occurred before Shah Jahan's reign

Answer: C. Explanation: The war demonstrates transfer vulnerability and factional stakes, but administrative structures did not vanish overnight.

Q80. A response turns Topic 21 into a full account of Akbar, Shivaji and Mughal culture. What is the correction?

- A. omit mansab history altogether
- B. move all chronology to Topic 24
- C. Repeat every adjacent package word for word
- D. Use cross-links: retain foundations, bridges and boundaries without duplicating owner topics

Answer: D. Explanation: The topic needs the Akbar-Jahangir foundations and later bridges, but ownership boundaries protect clarity and causal precision.

Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 21

Drill	Prompt	Minimum route	Fatal trap
A	Date accession.	Jahangir dies 1627 -> enthronement 1628	one undifferentiated date
B	Frame consolidation.	Bundela/Lodi/Hugli/frontiers -> varied control forms	uniform annexation
C	Assess magnificence.	monuments -> ideology/labour -> Moosvi fiscal caution	buildings caused collapse
D	Define ruling class.	ranked service elite -> mansab/office/jagir/service	ethnic caste
E	Read composition.	123 to 518 -> share versus absolute number	fixed Irani/Turani blocs
F	Define mansab terms.	zat/sawar/dagh/chehra	rank equals ready army
G	Define jagir terms.	revenue assignment + jama/hasil	private landownership
H	Explain du-aspa.	double specified sawar, not zat	doubling all rank
I	Explain muster ratios.	one-third/one-fourth/one-fifth	nominal equals actual
J	Explain month-scale.	realised yield -> salary/remount adjustment	bonus
K	Evaluate fiscal strain.	jama index 100-176 vs elite 123-518 -> adaptation	inevitable collapse
L	Bound succession.	1657 illness -> networks -> Dharmat/Samugarh -> stop	liberal/orthodox referendum

PYQ status: zero direct verified Topic-21 CSE Prelims/GS-I routes, 2018-2026. Original drills are not PYQs; Mains has no objective key.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART XIII - PYQ AUDIT AND PRACTICE

Transparent PYQ ownership audit

Local routing ledgers for CSE Prelims and GS-I (2018-2026), together with available official/OCR paper material, were searched for direct questions on Shah Jahan, Mughal ruling class/nobility, mansabdari evolution, zat/sawar, du-aspa sih-aspa, month-scale, jagir/jama/hasil, Shahjahanabad, the war of succession and golden-age assessment. No direct verified CSE Prelims or GS-I question was located for this Topic 21 ownership cluster. This is a PYQ gap, not permission to manufacture a question or an official answer key. Topic 16 owns Akbar's general mansabdari foundation; Topic 24 owns broad Mughal art/economy/traveller questions. Consequently the practice below is original and clearly marked as such. No options from an alleged PYQ have been reconstructed or reordered.

PART XIV - EXAMINER-GRADE MAINS PRACTICE WITH SOLUTIONS

Mains 1. 10 marks | 'Shah Jahan's reign was both the zenith of Mughal grandeur and a period of structural strain.' Discuss.

Directive alignment: weigh two propositions, then give a graded verdict.

Model solution: Shah Jahan's reign (1628-1658) was a peak of visible imperial capacity, but that capacity did not remove the growing gap between revenue claims and service claims. The correct verdict is not 'golden age or crisis'; it is grandeur alongside managed strain.

First, the court could coordinate exceptional material and political display. The Taj Mahal, Red Fort, Jama Masjid and the 1638 Shahjahanabad project required workshops, labour, materials and court direction. They demonstrate organisational reach and a ruler-centred language of sovereignty. The 1633 Ahmadnagar outcome and 1636 Deccan settlement similarly show that the state could combine force and hierarchy.

Second, the fiscal-military system exposed limits. The Satish Chandra-based index in the assigned material moves from 100 (1595) to about 176 (1656-57), but mansab and high-rank claims grew faster. The month-scale acknowledged that a nominal twelve-month jagir could produce only an eight-, six- or lower-month effective return. This constrained pay and remount capacity. Deccan three-to-four-month cases make the mismatch particularly clear,

though war, terrain and collection problems-not merely fraud-must explain it.

Finally, Balkh (1646-47) and Qandahar's loss in 1649 separate mobilisation from durable strategic success; the 1657-58 succession war exposed transfer vulnerability. Thus grandeur was real, but it was unevenly sustained. The roots of later jagirdari pressure were visible without making Shah Jahan's reign an already collapsed state.

Why this earns marks: It answers both sides, names monuments, revenue evidence and campaigns, explains a mechanism, and qualifies the later-crisis claim.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Mains 1. 10 marks | 'Shah Jahan's reign was both the zenith of Mughal grandeur and a period...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 1. 10 marks | 'Shah Jahan's reign was both the zenith of Mughal grandeur and a period...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 2. 15 marks | Examine how the composition and recruitment of the Mughal ruling class under Shah Jahan combined integration with competition.

Directive alignment: explain composition, recruitment and the two-sided consequence.

Model solution: The Mughal ruling class under Shah Jahan was a composite service elite rather than a homogeneous ethnicity or a modern civil service. Its diversity strengthened imperial reach but made rank, jagir and princely patronage intensely competitive.

Its core consisted of high mansabdars and household-connected servants linked to the emperor through rank, command, jagir and favour. Court language included Turanis, Iranis, Hindustani/Indian Muslims including Shaikhzada lineages, Rajputs, Afghans, Deccanis and other entrants. This is not a rigid census: labels can reflect origin, migration, regional association or political network. The safest scholarly trend is a widening Indian element across the Akbar-Jahangir-Shah Jahan sequence while immigrant groups remained significant; no uncited percentage should be used.

Recruitment mixed competence with patronage. Military usefulness, administrative skill, frontier knowledge, recommendation, kinship and household attachment could advance a person. Rajput houses, including Kachhwahas, gained honour, rank and service opportunity, but house-specific calculation prevents a claim of uniform Rajput loyalty. Shahji Bhonsale is a bounded Deccan example: elite incorporation does not equal mass Maratha integration.

The system integrated local links and talent into an imperial hierarchy. Yet formal non-heredity did not erase social reproduction: families retained clients, reputations and court familiarity. When rank and good jagirs were scarce, those networks became sites of competition. In 1657-58, uncertainty over which prince would allocate offices transformed ordinary patronage into factional alignment.

Therefore diversity was a governing resource and a structural risk. It should be analysed through changing patrons and incentives, not fixed ethnic camps.

Why this earns marks: It defines the object, names groups with caution, supplies Rajput/Maratha evidence, explains recruitment and connects composition to succession politics.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Mains 2. 15 marks | Examine how the composition and recruitment of the Mughal ruling class...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 2. 15 marks | Examine how the composition and recruitment of the Mughal ruling class...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 3. 15 marks | Trace the evolution of the mansabdari system from Akbar to Shah Jahan. Was Shah Jahan an innovator or an adjuster?

Directive alignment: trace continuity and change, then classify Shah Jahan accurately.

Model solution: Shah Jahan was principally an adjuster of a mature mansabdari framework, not its inventor. Akbar's system linked graded service to imperial dependence; Jahangir and Shah Jahan adapted its military and fiscal operation as claims became heavier.

Under Akbar, the mature dual rank of c.1595-96 separated **zat**, personal status and pay grade, from **sawar**, cavalry obligation. This distinction enabled the centre to rank men while specifying service. Akbar also systematised dagh and chehra within a longer control lineage: Alauddin Khalji had used branding/descriptive control and Sher Shah revived/adapted it. Their purpose was to reduce divergence between paper contingent and actual force.

Jahangir's du-aspa sih-aspa is the next adjustment. It could double or triple specified cavalry obligation without raising zat. This device must not be described as doubling the whole rank. It shows how the state could enhance military claims without a corresponding rise in personal status.

Shah Jahan inherited this grammar. His source-grounded contingent ratios and muster adjustments require contextual reading rather than a universal formula. More important was the tension between rising mansab/salary claims and jagir realisation. Month-rating scaled entitlement to effective revenue, while dagh/chehra still confronted evasion such as temporary borrowed horses.

Thus Shah Jahan's reign demonstrates mature adjustment under pressure: flexible enough to maintain service and imperial dependence, but vulnerable where nominal rank outran reliable support. The later jagirdari crisis intensified this tension; it should not be retrojected as a completed outcome.

Why this earns marks: The answer traces all three reigns, corrects dagh provenance and du-aspa/zat traps, and reaches a nuanced innovator-versus-adjuster verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **trace** requires a direct position on “Mains 3. 15 marks | Trace the evolution of the mansabdari system from Akbar to Shah Jahan...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 3. 15 marks | Trace the evolution of the mansabdari system from Akbar to Shah Jahan...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 4. 10 marks | Explain du-aspa sih-aspa and the month-scale. How did each address a different Mughal problem?

Directive alignment: define both devices and compare their functions.

Model solution: Du-aspa sih-aspa and the month-scale operated at different points in the Mughal service system. The first adjusted the military obligation; the second adjusted fiscal entitlement to effective jagir value.

Du-aspa sih-aspa appears under Jahangir in the assigned source tradition. It allowed a specified sawar obligation to be doubled or tripled without raising the mansabdar's zat. Its function was to obtain additional cavalry capacity while retaining the distinction between personal rank and service duty. It did not double the whole mansab or transform status.

The month-scale belongs to the fiscal response visible under Shah Jahan. A jagir nominally valued at twelve months could yield an eight-, six- or lower-month effective return; pay and sawar support were scaled accordingly. The source illustration of Rs 40, Rs 30 and Rs 25 must be treated as a category-specific sawar-pay example, not a universal schedule. Deccan three-to-four-month ratings show why the device could generate discontent and weaken remount capacity.

Both devices show an adaptive state: one calibrated demand for cavalry, the other calibrated claims to revenue realisation. Neither proves automatic collapse. Their combined significance is that military promise depended upon fiscal support.

Why this earns marks: It defines terms, distinguishes zat from sawar, explains the accounting mechanism and avoids turning examples into universal data.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Mains 4. 10 marks | Explain du-aspa sih-aspa and the month-scale. How did each address a...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 4. 10 marks | Explain du-aspa sih-aspa and the month-scale. How did each address a...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 5. 15 marks | Distinguish jagir, jama and hasil. Analyse how their relationship shaped Mughal political economy.

Directive alignment: define each term and move from vocabulary to causal analysis.

Model solution: A jagir was a service-linked assignment of a state revenue claim; jama was assessed or estimated revenue; hasil was actual realised collection. Their relationship explains why Mughal political economy cannot be reduced to a map of privately owned estates.

The jagirdar held an imperial assignment, normally transferable, rather than unrestricted ownership of land or province. This differed from the locally rooted and variable position of a zamindar. Transfer helped retain central leverage, though short tenure could create incentives for intensive extraction and competition for better assignments. Khalisa, by contrast, referred to revenue retained for the crown.

Jama represented a fiscal estimate or claim, whereas hasil recorded realisation. A gap could arise from optimistic assessment, survey problems, war, incomplete control, collection cost, resistance or disrupted cultivation. Therefore a jagir whose paper jama appeared adequate could still fail to fund a full annual entitlement. The month-scale translated that gap into effective months and adjusted salary/service support.

The political consequence was triangular. The centre sought to reward and bind mansabdars; jagirdars sought viable returns and remount resources; zamindars and cultivators faced local negotiation and revenue pressure. The argument should not assume uniform oppression or treat jama as GDP. Rather, it identifies a system in which central claims, local conditions and service obligations were continuously reconciled.

Why this earns marks: It gives exact definitions, distinguishes jagirdar from zamindar, names mechanisms for the jama-hasil gap and links vocabulary to incentives without overclaiming.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on “Mains 5. 15 marks | Distinguish jagir, jama and hasil. Analyse how their relationship...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 5. 15 marks | Distinguish jagir, jama and hasil. Analyse how their relationship...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 6. 20 marks | Analyse the Deccan as a source of both imperial opportunity and fiscal pressure during Shah Jahan's reign.

Directive alignment: balance opportunity and pressure, with a bounded Deccan chronology.

Model solution: Under Shah Jahan, the Deccan was not merely a frontier to be coloured on an imperial map. It offered forts, routes, tributary possibilities, local military resources and nominal revenue, while simultaneously imposing the costs of war, control and uncertain collection. Its political economy helps explain why expansion could increase both resources and fiscal pressure.

On the opportunity side, the end of Ahmadnagar's Nizam Shahi line at Daulatabad in 1633 and the 1636 settlement with Bijapur and Golconda displayed real Mughal capacity to combine conquest, suzerainty and negotiation. The Deccan also offered access to local knowledge and mobile military labour. Shahji Bhonsale's service trajectory is a limited example of elite movement across Deccani and Mughal worlds. Such incorporation broadened imperial options, but it must not be exaggerated into stable mass Maratha integration.

The pressure side lies in the conversion of nominal resource into usable yield. The assigned Satish Chandra-based material notes highly inflated Deccan jama and cases rated at only three to four months. This mismatch can arise from terrain, distance, warfare, incomplete control, survey limits and collection costs, not only official deceit. A short-rated assignment could reduce effective income and remount capacity, generate competition for better postings, and intensify pressure on intermediaries and producers.

The renewed interventions of 1656-57 reinforce the point that a settlement did not eliminate claims. Expansion added garrisons, commanders and princely commands even where it added revenue prospects. Therefore Deccan policy was a managed bargain between strategy and fiscal realisation, not a simple gain or loss. The mature crisis belongs later, but Shah Jahan's Deccan shows its important preconditions.

Why this earns marks: It uses 1633, 1636, Shahji and 3-4 month evidence; explains a multi-causal mechanism; and keeps Topic 23's later narrative outside the answer.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on “Mains 6. 20 marks | Analyse the Deccan as a source of both imperial opportunity and fiscal...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 6. 20 marks | Analyse the Deccan as a source of both imperial opportunity and fiscal...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 7. 15 marks | 'Court grandeur under Shah Jahan was a political economy, not merely an aesthetic achievement.' Discuss.

Directive alignment: explain political and economic mechanisms while qualifying causal claims.

Model solution: Shah Jahan's court grandeur was political economy because monuments and ceremonial centres mobilised resources, organised skilled work, structured urban demand and represented a hierarchy of sovereignty. It was not simply aesthetic display, but neither can it be treated as a self-evident cause of fiscal collapse.

The Taj Mahal, Red Fort, Jama Masjid and Shahjahanabad required materials, transport, labour, workshops, design and supervision. The 1638 foundation/transfer process for Shahjahanabad made the court's presence spatially legible through fortress, mosque, markets and circulation. These projects demonstrate a state and court able to concentrate demand and make political authority visible. Court consumption could support artisans and suppliers, especially within urban markets.

Yet the distributional question remains. The surplus financing courtly consumption was gathered in a hierarchical revenue order in which jagirdars, zamindars and cultivators occupied unequal positions. Court splendour does not prove universal prosperity. Nor does the Taj Mahal alone demonstrate a causal route to Mughal decline: such a claim would need comparative evidence on spending, revenue realisation, warfare and jagir claims that cannot be inferred from the monument itself.

A current static link is urban heritage: the accessible SRDC Jama Masjid precinct material discusses streets, facilities and a visual/physical Red Fort link. It cannot be converted into a dated six-month CA claim or evidence about seventeenth-century accounts. Thus grandeur is best read as material sovereignty embedded in a wider extractive and productive system.

Why this earns marks: It makes monuments analytical, uses Shahjahanabad precisely, includes craft/market and extraction dimensions, and explicitly rejects a single-cause fallacy.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Mains 7. 15 marks | 'Court grandeur under Shah Jahan was a political economy, not merely an...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mains 7. 15 marks | 'Court grandeur under Shah Jahan was a political economy, not merely an...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 8. 20 marks | How did the 1657-58 succession struggle reveal the strengths and vulnerabilities of Mughal ruling-class politics?

Directive alignment: connect ruling class and succession with a balanced institutional verdict.

Model solution: The 1657-58 succession struggle revealed the Mughal ruling class as both an integrative instrument of empire and a vulnerable patronage order when sovereign allocation became uncertain. The illness of Shah Jahan did not create faction from nothing; it raised the stakes of an elite structure already organised around rank, household, command and jagir.

Its strength lay in the empire's ability to mobilise through diverse service networks. High mansabdars, Rajput houses, Turani and Irani migrants, Hindustani Muslim lineages, Afghans, Deccanis and other entrants could be linked to an emperor through mansab, reward and command. Princes also possessed regional bases: Dara's courtly position, Shuja's Bengal, Aurangzeb's Deccan and Murad's Gujarat supplied potential manpower and resources. Dharmat and Samugarh in 1658 demonstrate that elite command and regional mobilisation were real capacities.

The same structure was vulnerable because the polity had no fixed primogeniture rule. When Shah Jahan's illness made the future allocator of office uncertain, nobles calculated survival, reward, kin ties and immediate military prospects. Alignments were not rigid ethnic camps; they were shifting patronage choices. The later battles of Khajwa

and Deorai, Murad's removal and Shah Jahan's confinement show that military victory had to be converted into control of the imperial centre.

The war did not instantly dissolve administration or revenue. It did, however, expose a transfer mechanism dependent on personal power rather than a settled rule. A graded conclusion is therefore appropriate: the composite ruling class made empire governable in normal times, but its competitive patronage networks could become a vector of intense conflict at dynastic transition.

Why this earns marks: It gives chronology, princes and battles, rejects ethnic determinism, explains incentives and distinguishes violent transfer from instant collapse.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Mains 8. 20 marks | How did the 1657-58 succession struggle reveal the strengths and...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 8. 20 marks | How did the 1657-58 succession struggle reveal the strengths and...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 9. 15 marks | Evaluate Padshahnama, administrative data, monuments and travellers as sources for Shah Jahan's reign.

Directive alignment: evaluate source reach and limitations rather than merely list sources.

Model solution: Shah Jahan's reign is best reconstructed by triangulating genres, because each source type illuminates a different register of imperial life and carries a different silence.

Padshahnama and related court chronicles are strong for ceremony, campaigns, appointments, titulature and the court's claim to orderly sovereignty. They can date and frame elite actions, but their legitimising purpose may understate failure, coercion and social suffering. Amal-i-Salih and Shah Jahan Nama traditions require the same attention to genre and proximity.

Administrative tables and mansab/jagir data are indispensable for patterns in rank, assessed revenue and assignment. They make the jama-versus-mansab problem visible. But nominal categories are not automatically actual cash, effective troops or a complete population. The 100/about 122/about 176 jama index must therefore be called an assessed-revenue index from a cited modern synthesis, not GDP.

Monuments such as the Taj Mahal and Red Fort reveal material coordination, ideology and elite demand. They cannot by themselves calculate fiscal health. Travellers such as Tavernier, Bernier and Manucci supply observations on court, trade and cities, but their outsider vantage, comparative rhetoric and chronology must be checked; Bernier's later observations cannot be transparently universalised for Shah Jahan.

Thus the best method is a source-reach matrix: chronicle for claim and appointment; record for administrative pattern; monument for material sovereignty; traveller for situated observation. Agreement strengthens an inference, while contradiction should be explained rather than erased.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates four evidence types, gives specific uses and limits, treats the index correctly, and turns source criticism into a method.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “Mains 9. 15 marks | Evaluate Padshahnama, administrative data, monuments and travellers as...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 9. 15 marks | Evaluate Padshahnama, administrative data, monuments and travellers as...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 10. 20 marks | 'The fiscal pressures of Shah Jahan's reign were real, but the language of inevitable collapse is misleading.' Evaluate.

Directive alignment: establish pressure, test inevitability, and give a time-sensitive verdict.

Model solution: Fiscal pressures under Shah Jahan were real because the Mughal service system had to reconcile expanding rank and cavalry claims with unevenly realised revenue. Yet 'inevitable collapse' is misleading because the state still adjusted, mobilised and represented authority effectively; the mature jagirdari crisis belongs to a later chronology.

The pressure is visible in three linked facts. First, the assigned Satish Chandra-based jama index rises from 100 in 1595 to approximately 122 in 1627 and approximately 176 in 1656-57, while the source describes mansab/rank claims as growing faster. Second, jama was an assessment, not hasil. Hence a jagir with a twelve-month paper valuation might produce an eight-, six- or lower-month effective return. The month-scale reduced entitlement and service support to that rating; the source's Rs 40/30/25 illustration must remain category-specific. Third, Deccan cases rated at three to four months show how war, terrain, control and collection could make nominal expansion fiscally thin.

These pressures had consequences: weaker remount capacity, demand for better assignments, factional patronage and possible pressure on local revenue channels. Frontier campaigns in Balkh and Qandahar added logistical demands, while 1657-58 made office allocation politically explosive.

However, the same evidence shows adaptation. The month-scale was a management device; dagh/chehra and contingent rules sought verification; the court still coordinated monuments and capital-making; Deccan settlements and military mobilisation remained possible. Neither a monument nor a month rating proves collapse.

The best conclusion is chronological: Shah Jahan's reign incubated claim-resource tension within a functioning imperial order. Later extended war and post-Aurangzeb conditions intensified the crisis, but inevitability should not be read backward.

Why this earns marks: It builds a mechanism from terminology and evidence, gives counter-evidence of adaptation, and ends with a precise, non-deterministic chronology.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “Mains 10. 20 marks | 'The fiscal pressures of Shah Jahan's reign were real, but the...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Mains 10. 20 marks | 'The fiscal pressures of Shah Jahan's reign were real, but the...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.